

Microsoft Defender Suite

XDR portfolio spanning endpoints, identity, email, cloud apps, and cloud workloads

Overview

The Microsoft Defender family delivers Extended Detection and Response (XDR) across the modern attack surface. Individual products correlate signal into the Microsoft Defender XDR portal for unified incident and alert triage, complementing Sentinel's broader SIEM/SOAR role.

Product Family

	Protects
Defender for Endpoint	Windows/Linux/macOS/mobile — EDR, vulnerability management, attack surface reduction
Defender for Identity	On-prem AD — detects lateral movement, DCSync, Kerberoasting via domain controller sensors
Defender for Office 365	Email/collaboration — phishing, malware, Safe Links/Attachments, campaign views
Defender for Cloud Apps	SaaS/CASB — shadow IT discovery, session/access policies, OAuth app governance
Defender for Cloud	Multi-cloud CSPM + CWPP — posture management and workload protection (Azure/AWS/GCP)
Defender Vulnerability Management	Continuous discovery, risk-based prioritization, remediation tracking

Defender for Cloud — CSPM/CWPP

- **Secure Score** — weighted, actionable posture metric across recommendations
- **Regulatory compliance dashboard** — maps controls to CIS, PCI-DSS, ISO 27001, NIST
- **Workload protection plans** — per-resource-type (servers, storage, SQL, containers, Key Vault, App Service)

- **Agentless scanning** — VM disk and container image scanning without in-guest agents
- **Multi-cloud connectors** — onboard AWS (via CloudFormation) and GCP (via Terraform/console) for unified posture
- **Attack path analysis** — graph-based visualization of exploitable chains toward crown-jewel assets

Defender for Endpoint — Key Concepts

- **Device groups & tags** drive RBAC and automation scoping
- **Attack Surface Reduction (ASR) rules** block common malware/exploit techniques (e.g., Office macro abuse)
- **Automated Investigation & Remediation (AIR)** auto-triages and remediates low-complexity alerts
- **Live Response** gives responders a remote shell for forensic collection and containment
- **Threat & Vulnerability Management** ties CVE exposure directly to device inventory

Unified Incident Correlation

Defender XDR automatically correlates alerts across endpoint, identity, email, and cloud app signals into a single **incident** with a shared attack story — reducing alert fatigue versus triaging each product console independently. Sentinel can further ingest these as high-fidelity incidents via the Microsoft Defender XDR connector.

Common Pitfalls

	Fix
Running ASR rules straight to block mode	Pilot in audit mode first, review impacted users/apps, then enforce
Ignoring Secure Score recommendations as noise	Triage by weighted risk reduction, not raw count; a few items often move the score most
Defender for Cloud enabled without workload plans	Free tier is CSPM-only; enable paid plans for actual threat detection (CWPP)

Use unified Defender XDR portal for cross-signal incident correlation

**Treating each
Defender console as
independent**

**No automated
response to high-
confidence alerts**

Wire AIR / Logic Apps playbooks for auto-containment on high-fidelity detections

Interview / Exam Quick Hits

- Defender for Cloud **Free tier** = CSPM recommendations only; **plans** (paid) add CWPP threat detection
- Defender for Identity sensors run **on domain controllers/AD FS servers**, not endpoints
- Secure Score recommendations are weighted by **potential risk reduction**, not simple count
- ASR rules can run in **audit mode** before enforcement to validate false-positive impact
- Defender for Cloud Apps enforces real-time control via **reverse proxy (Conditional Access App Control)**